

UPSTRIDE RESOURCES

FREE PRACTICAL DIGITAL GROWTH SERIES

CRM & Client Management Playbook

Create a trusted system for relationships, pipeline, and service.

A practical guide to CRM structure, adoption, data quality, follow-up, and client visibility.

STRATEGY > SYSTEM > SCALE

YOUR NEXT STEP FORWARD

How to use this playbook

A practical guide to CRM structure, adoption, data quality, follow-up, and client visibility.

**READ**

Understand the operating model.

**ASSESS**

Score your current state honestly.

**BUILD**

Complete one focused pilot.

**REVIEW**

Use evidence to improve the system.

A note on responsible use

This free publication is for educational and planning purposes. Adapt every recommendation to your business, customers, contracts, privacy obligations, security requirements, and local laws. It is not legal, financial, accounting, cybersecurity, or regulatory advice. Product and platform capabilities change; verify current requirements before implementation.



BASELINE

Where are you now?

Rate each statement from 1 (not true yet) to 5 (consistently true). Use the lowest scores to choose your first improvement.

01 We have a shared definition of success for define.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

02 The current workflow and ownership are documented and understood.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

03 Our tools and data have clear sources of truth.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

04 Important exceptions are identified and assigned to a person.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

05 We measure outcomes, quality, and adoption - not only activity.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

06 The team reviews and improves the system on a regular cadence.

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

YOUR BASELINE SCORE

6-14 START | 15-23 STABILIZE | 24-30 SCALE



THE UPSTRIDE FRAMEWORK

Five moves that build momentum

Use this sequence to move from a scattered effort to a visible, repeatable system.

01**DEFINE**

Set the direction and desired outcome.

02**STRUCTURE**

Remove ambiguity and unnecessary friction.

03**CAPTURE**

Create the core workflow and supporting assets.

04**ACT**

Launch with ownership, controls, and visibility.

05**GOVERN**

Learn from evidence and strengthen the system.

DEFINE IN PRACTICE

Define the operating model

The CRM should reflect how your team actually wins, serves, and retains customers.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Agree on lifecycle and pipeline stages

Agree on lifecycle and pipeline stages.

2

Define ownership at every stage

Define ownership at every stage.

3

Document stage entry and exit criteria

Document stage entry and exit criteria.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

STRUCTURE IN PRACTICE

Structure useful data

Capture only information that supports a decision, action, experience, or required record.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Separate company, person, deal, and activity

Separate company, person, deal, and activity.

2

Use controlled values for reporting fields

Use controlled values for reporting fields.

3

Name the source of truth for each field

Name the source of truth for each field.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

CAPTURE IN PRACTICE

Make capture easy

Adoption rises when the system reduces duplicate work and fits normal workflows.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Automate safe, objective data capture

Automate safe, objective data capture.

2

Use short role-specific views

Use short role-specific views.

3

Make the next action visible

Make the next action visible.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

ACT IN PRACTICE

Enable consistent action

Reminders, sequences, routing, and service tasks should support ownership without noise.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Set response and follow-up standards

Set response and follow-up standards.

2

Trigger tasks from stage changes

Trigger tasks from stage changes.

3

Create exception queues for attention

Create exception queues for attention.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?

GOVERN IN PRACTICE

Govern and improve

Data quality and permissions require recurring ownership, not a one-time cleanup.

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Make the next right action obvious, owned, and measurable.

Three actions to take

1

Review duplicates and missing fields

Review duplicates and missing fields.

2

Limit exports and sensitive data access

Limit exports and sensitive data access.

3

Retire unused fields and reports

Retire unused fields and reports.

DECISION PROMPT

What would become easier for the customer or the team if this part of the system worked reliably every time?



MOVE FROM IDEA TO PILOT

A focused implementation sprint

Keep the first implementation narrow enough to learn quickly and important enough to matter.

1

Map lifecycle and owners

DAYS 1-3

2

Define fields and sources

DAYS 4-7

3

Configure pipelines and views

DAYS 8-11

4

Import a cleaned sample

DAYS 12-16

5

Build follow-up rules

DAYS 17-21

6

Train by role

DAYS 22-26

7

Review adoption and quality

DAYS 27-30



MAKE IT CONCRETE

One-page system brief

Complete this before selecting tools or building assets. Short, specific answers are more useful than broad ambition.

01 LIFECYCLE STAGES

02 OWNER BY STAGE

03 REQUIRED DECISION FIELDS

04 NEXT-ACTION RULE

05 AUTOMATION AND INTEGRATION

06 DATA QUALITY REVIEW OWNER



EVIDENCE OVER ACTIVITY

A practical scorecard

Choose a small set of measures that show customer value, operational quality, and sustainable adoption.

MEASURE	BASELINE	TARGET	CADENCE
Record completeness			
Follow-up compliance			
Stage conversion			
Pipeline velocity			
Forecast hygiene			

REVIEW QUESTION

What changed, why did it change, and what will we do next?



READY TO MOVE FORWARD?

Final readiness check

A healthy launch has clarity, ownership, safeguards, measurement, and a defined next review.

- ☐ The desired business and customer outcome is specific.
- ☐ A named owner is accountable for the system.
- ☐ The normal workflow and important exceptions are documented.
- ☐ Data access, privacy, and security requirements are reviewed.
- ☐ Users have been trained in the real workflow.
- ☐ Success measures have baselines, targets, and owners.
- ☐ A rollback or recovery path exists where needed.
- ☐ The first improvement review is scheduled.

YOUR NEXT STEP FORWARD

Continue with CRM & Client Management Specialist.

See the guided learning path: upstride-three.vercel.app/academy/crm-client-management

FREE GUIDE TO GUIDED PRACTICE

Ready to build the skill?

This playbook gives you the framework. The matching Upstride Academy program helps you apply it through structured lessons, practical projects, downloadable tools, and a capstone.

RECOMMENDED PROGRAM

CRM & Client Management Specialist

UPSTRIDE ACADEMY | PRACTICAL, PROJECT-BASED LEARNING

What the program helps you do

1

Design lifecycle stages, fields, and ownership

Design lifecycle stages, fields, and ownership through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

2

Build consistent follow-up and client workflows

Build consistent follow-up and client workflows through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

3

Configure a practical CRM operating model

Configure a practical CRM operating model through guided exercises and feedback-ready project work.

CHOOSE YOUR SUPPORT LEVEL

Basic | Pro | Mentored

Review current package details and availability on the course page before enrolling.

View the program and enroll

upstride-three.vercel.app/academy/crm-client-management